The general (“background”) rate of extinction is roughly 10 percent of species every million years. This is far exceeded during mass extinctions, which always mark the boundary between two geological periods. In a mass extinction, over 75 percent of species are lost, usually in less than 2 million years. Scientists do not understand all the factors responsible for these events, though they are agreed on some. Increased volcanic activity, changes in the composition of the atmosphere and oceans, climate change, sea level rises and falls, tectonic movement of the continents, and meteor impacts are all likely causes. Some scientists suggest we have now entered a sixth mass extinction, this time the result of human activity.



The meteor that hit Earth at the end of the Cretaceous period was traveling at 40,000 mph (64,000 kph). Its power was a billion times greater than the Hiroshima atomic bomb.